



NEW TERRITORY: Els
(in blue) inspects the
course in Delhi

sports GOLF

TUSSLE FOR TURF

Photographs by RAVI S SAHNI

The arrival of two European Tour events made February Indian golf's million-dollar month and showcased its world class pros. The step to the next level though will need money—and more.

■ **By Sharda Ugra**

It was 1997 and a fellow called Eldrick Woods was tearing up Augusta National leading the third round of the US Masters by nine shots. At the end of the day his nearest rival, Colin Montgomerie was asked if he thought Woods was going to win. The Scot held on to his famous

temper and asked his inquisitor with polite puzzlement, "Have you been on vacation? Have you only just arrived?"

Tiger is yet to be lured to India—a \$3 million appearance fee may be a wee glitch—but Ernie Els showed up and Montgomerie and others will be here soon. To wonder why the world's leading golf pros are heading this way is to deserve the full 'Monty' treatment.

Have you been on vacation? Don't you know? Indian golf has arrived.

In the space of a month, India staged its first European Tour event, the Emaar-MGF Indian Masters at the Delhi Golf Club (DGC) and will soon host the Johnnie Walker Classic. With four Asian Tour events this year, India is now second to China as an Asian Tour host. Asian Tour Executive Chairman